

The Wolf in Sheep's Clothing

A wolf lived near a hillside pasture where a shepherd guarded a large flock of sheep. The wolf watched from the trees and wanted an easy meal, but the shepherd's dogs barked whenever he came near. The sheep also scattered at the sight of him. After several failed attempts, the wolf understood that his own appearance warned everyone before he could get close.

One evening, the wolf found the fleece of a sheep caught on a thorn bush. He pulled it over his back and looked at himself in a pool of water. From a distance, he did resemble one of the flock. The next morning he walked slowly among the sheep with his head lowered. The shepherd saw only another woolly shape and did not notice the wolf's eyes beneath the fleece.

At first the plan seemed successful. The wolf came close to the flock, and the sheep did not run. He felt clever and proud. But pretending required constant care. He had to move slowly when he wanted to run, chew grass when he wanted meat, and stay silent when the dogs passed. Still, he waited for evening, when the shepherd would lead the sheep into the pen.

As dusk fell, the shepherd counted the flock. He noticed a large sheep he did not recognize and thought it would make a good meal for the next day's celebration. He took the disguised wolf into a separate stall. The wolf was pleased at first, believing he had been given a private chance to choose his prey. But when the shepherd returned carrying a rope, the wolf understood too late that he had deceived the wrong person.

The wolf escaped only by tearing free of the borrowed fleece and running into the forest. He lost both his disguise and his chance at the flock. The shepherd later found the fleece and realized what had happened. He became more careful when counting his animals, and the sheep learned to stay close to one another. The wolf learned a harsher lesson: a false appearance may fool others briefly, but it can also lead a

deceiver into danger. Trust should be earned by honest conduct, not borrowed by costume.